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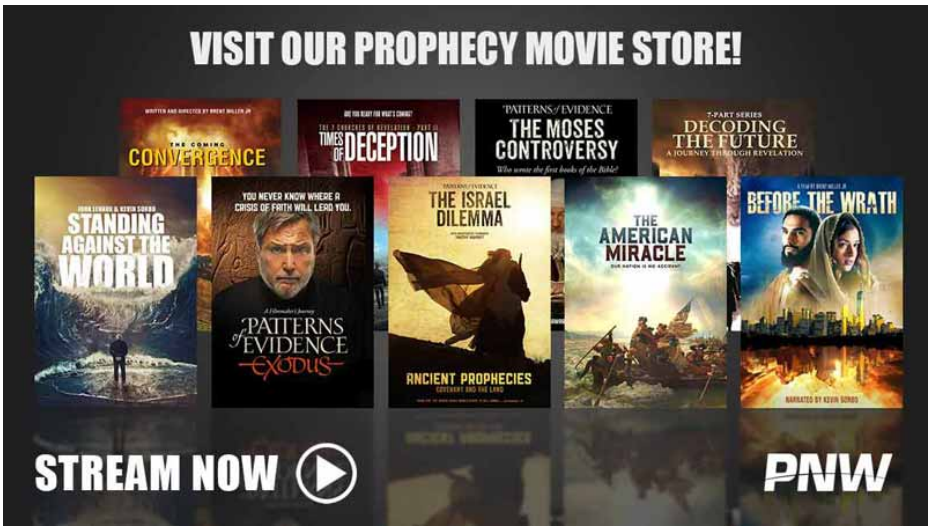
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ARTICLE

She Survived Her Execution - Should Christians Support The Death Penalty?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 07, 2026

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America is suddenly confronting the death penalty again--and from dramatically different directions.



On September 30, Tennessee attempted to execute convicted murderer Christa Pike by lethal injection. It didn't work. After receiving two doses of pentobarbital, Pike survived and was rushed to a hospital, where she remained unconscious for days. She has now regained consciousness and is speaking, while Tennessee has halted further executions pending an investigation into what went wrong.

At almost the same time, President Donald Trump approved an extraordinarily rare execution: former Army Maj. Nidal Hasan is to be put to death by military firing squad for murdering 13 people in the 2009 Fort Hood massacre. If carried out, it would be America's first military execution since 1961.

Meanwhile, Idaho has made the firing squad its primary method of execution--a change that followed the state's failed attempt in 2024 to execute longtime death-row inmate Thomas Creech by lethal injection.

Suddenly, capital punishment is back in the headlines.

For Christians, however, the question goes deeper than lethal injection versus firing squad:

Can followers of Jesus support the death penalty?

It is tempting to answer emotionally. Pike's crime--the brutal 1995 torture and murder of 19-year-old Colleen Slemmer--was horrific. What happened in Tennessee's execution chamber was also deeply troubling.

But Christians cannot build their theology of justice around which event produces the stronger emotional reaction.

The question is what Scripture teaches.

And while Christians have legitimate reasons to be cautious about how capital punishment is administered, the biblical case that government possesses the authority to impose it for the gravest crimes is strong.





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Why Genesis 9 Matters

Perhaps the clearest foundation appears in Genesis 9:6:

"Whoever sheds man's blood, by man his blood shall be shed; for in the image of God He made man."

This comes before the Mosaic Law. God gave this command to Noah following the Flood, and His reasoning is enormously important.

Murder warrants such severe judgment because human beings are made in God's image.

That turns a common objection to capital punishment on its head.

The death penalty is not necessarily based upon the idea that human life is cheap. Genesis 9 grounds it in precisely the opposite principle: human life is so valuable that deliberately destroying an innocent image-bearer can warrant the ultimate earthly penalty.

There is a profound moral difference between murdering an innocent person and government lawfully punishing the murderer.

One destroys justice. The other is intended to uphold it.

Government Bears The Sword

The New Testament does not simply abolish that principle.

Romans 13 describes civil government as God's servant for restraining and punishing evil. Paul says the governing authority "does not bear the sword in vain" and calls it "an avenger who carries out God's wrath on the wrongdoer."

Notice the contrast with the chapter immediately before it.

Romans 12 commands Christians not to avenge themselves.

Romans 13 gives government authority to punish wrongdoing.

That distinction is essential.

Christians are forbidden from personal vengeance. Government is charged with public justice.

A Christian can therefore forgive the murderer of a loved one while believing that a court has the authority to punish that murderer.

Forgiveness does not eliminate earthly consequences.

If it did, Christian forgiveness would logically require eliminating prisons and every other criminal penalty.



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But Didn't Jesus Teach Mercy?

Of course He did.

Jesus commanded His followers to forgive, love their enemies and turn the other cheek. Christians should never minimize those commands.

But Jesus was teaching believers how to respond personally to evil. "Turn the other cheek" does not mean police cannot arrest violent criminals, judges cannot sentence them or governments cannot protect innocent people.

Acts 25 contains an especially revealing statement.

Facing charges before Roman authorities, Paul declared:

"If then I am a wrongdoer and have committed anything for which I deserve to die, I do not seek to escape death."

Paul maintained his innocence, but he plainly acknowledged that some crimes could deserve death.

That is difficult to reconcile with the argument that Christianity categorically prohibits capital punishment.

Christians Still Have Reasons For Caution

Biblical authorization does not mean Christians should enthusiastically support every execution.

Government is administered by fallible human beings.

Judges can be wrong. Prosecutors can be wrong. Witnesses can lie. Evidence can be misunderstood. Jurors can make mistakes.

And execution cannot be reversed.

Scripture itself demanded extraordinary safeguards in capital cases. Multiple witnesses were required, false testimony was severely condemned and judges were repeatedly warned against corruption and partiality.

That principle should matter today.

If reasonable doubt about guilt remains, Christians should be extremely hesitant about an irreversible punishment.

There is also the question of how executions are conducted.

What happened to Pike deserves investigation. Government cannot claim authority to administer justice while being careless about how it exercises the most irreversible power it possesses.

Biblical justice does not require cruelty.

Mercy Does Not Cancel Justice

Perhaps the most powerful picture comes from the thief crucified beside Jesus.

The thief acknowledged that he was receiving a just punishment. Yet in his final hours he turned toward Christ.

Jesus told him:

"Today you will be with Me in Paradise."

Christ forgave him.

But He did not remove him from the cross.

The thief received eternal mercy while still facing earthly judgment.

That scene reminds us that forgiveness and punishment can coexist.

A murderer can repent. A victim's family can forgive. God can save the condemned.

And government can still administer justice.

Don't Forget The Victim

There is one final danger in debates surrounding cases like Pike's.

Eventually, the condemned prisoner can become the center of the story while the murdered victim almost disappears.

For three decades there have been appeals, hearings, clemency requests and now headlines about Christa Pike.

Colleen Slemmer received no such decades.

She was 19.

Whatever happens next in Tennessee, she cannot become a footnote.

An image-bearer of God was deliberately killed.

That is precisely why Genesis 9 treats murder with such gravity.

Christians can debate whether America's death-penalty system operates accurately enough, fairly enough or competently enough. They can demand overwhelming certainty. They can support clemency in particular cases. They can insist upon due process and humane treatment.

Those are legitimate debates.

But they are different from declaring capital punishment itself unbiblical.

Scripture gives civil government an authority individual Christians do not possess: the authority to wield the sword against grave evil.

That authority should make Christians sober, not bloodthirsty; cautious, not indifferent.

Mercy is real. Forgiveness is real. Redemption is real.

But justice is real too.

The biblical argument for capital punishment is ultimately not that human life is worth too little to protect.

It is that human life is worth so much that deliberately taking an innocent life can warrant the most serious punishment government can impose.

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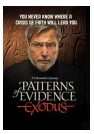
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